

The Russian Revolution

In 1917, at the height of World War I, two violent revolutions broke out in Russia. The first overthrew the czar (emperor) and brought the Russian Empire to an end. The second overthrew the whole government to establish the world's first communist state.

Russia joined World War I in 1914 on the Allied side. The war went badly for Russia and the Russian people grew dissatisfied with their government. When bread rationing was introduced in February 1917, there were riots in Petrograd (modern-day St. Petersburg). The government collapsed, and Czar Nicholas II gave up his throne.

Several revolutionary groups, including the Mensheviks, Kadets, and the Socialist Revolutionaries, formed a new provisional government. Their decision to keep fighting in the war led to people rising up in rebellion, which allowed the Bolshevik Party—led by Vladimir Lenin—to seize power in a second revolution in October. The Bolsheviks managed to suppress all other opposition movements and brought a new political system, known

as communism, to Russia. Communists believed that the country's wealth should be shared equally among its citizens. In 1922, the country was reorganized and renamed the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (the USSR).



▲ BUILDING A NEW WORLD

The Bolsheviks wanted to build a completely new state, where there was more equality between people who lived in urban and rural areas. Revolutionaries went out to educate people, such as these members of the Russian Railway Women Workers, about their new government.



▲ CIVIL WAR

The new Bolshevik government had to fight a violent civil war after 1918 to stay in power in Russia. The Bolsheviks (also called the Red Army) eventually won the war when the White Army (above) collapsed in June 1923. But fighting in Central Asia continued until 1934.



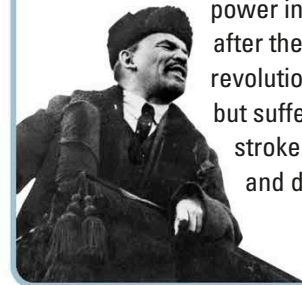
▲ THE FEBRUARY REVOLUTION

The first revolution took place in Russia in February 1917 after the country failed to defeat Germany in World War I and bread shortages led to riots in Petrograd. The army refused to suppress the riots and joined the protesters, leading to the downfall of the emperor and his government.

VLADIMIR LENIN

Vladimir Lenin (1870–1924) believed that people should have an equal share of wealth and was the world's first communist leader. He took

power in Russia after the second revolution of 1917, but suffered a stroke in 1922 and died in 1924.



▼ SYMBOLS OF THE REVOLUTION

After the revolutions, the Communist Party adopted the symbol of a crossed hammer and sickle on a red background. The hammer represented the city workers while the sickle was for the rural farmers. A new Russian flag was also designed based on this, which included a gold star above the hammer and sickle and stood for the Communist Party.

The hammer and sickle are prominent on communist posters of the period.

